

Eating Smart with Diabetes: The Filipino Guide

Which carbs spike blood sugar, which ones don't, and how to protect your kidneys & heart



W.G.M. Rivero MD
FPCP · DPSN
Nephrologist

williamriveromd.com

1 in 3

Filipinos has diabetes or prediabetes

<7%

HbA1c target for most patients

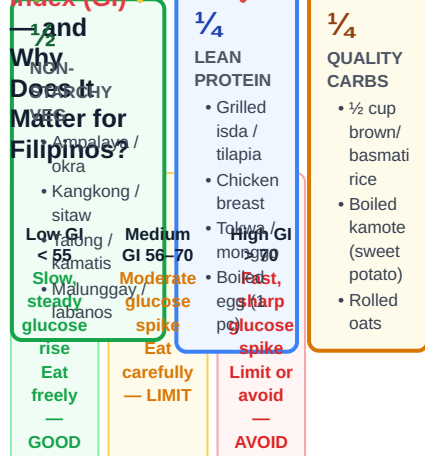
30–40%

Glucose spike cut by eating order alone

2

What Filipino Diabetes Plate

Why Does it Matter for Filipinos?



GL

(Glycemic Load) = GI ×

grams of carbs per serving ÷ 100. It is more practical than GI alone because it accounts for portion size. GL <10 = Low · GL 11–19 = Medium · GL ≥20 = High. Pages 2–3 show both GI and GL for each food.

3 Rice Strategies

— Lower the GI Without Giving It Up

TIP 1 Cool overnight in fridge

→ resistant starch forms → lowers GI by ~20–30%.
Reheat before eating.

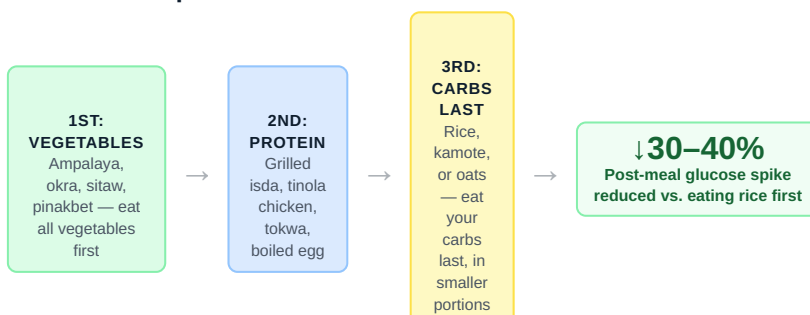
TIP 2 Add 1 tsp calamansi juice or vinegar to the rice → acid slows starch digestion, lowers GI ~20%.

TIP 3 Eat rice LAST after vegetables and protein → blunts the post-meal glucose spike by 30–40%.

TIP 4 Switch to basmati or brown rice (GI 58–68) and keep portions to ½ cup cooked per meal.

TIP 5 Mix with monggo or add okra — soluble fiber slows absorption and drops the meal's overall GI.

4 Eat in the Right Order — Meal Sequencing Cuts the Glucose Spike



Know Your Numbers

REMOVE (ADA 2025)

Fasting Glucose → **80–130** mg/dL

2-Hour Postprandial Glucose → **<180** mg/dL

HbA1c (elderly/frail) → **<8%** (less strict target)

Hypoglycemia → **<70** mg/dL

Targets are individualized — ask your doctor if you are elderly, pregnant, or have CKD or frequent hypoglycemia

USE
INSTEAD

½ cup cold/
basmati rice +
boiled kamote

Black barako
coffee or
salabat (no
sugar)

Sotanghon
soup with
vegetables (GI
35)

1 boiled egg +
1 guava or
green mango

Fresh
calamansi
juice
(unsweetened)
+ water

Bayabas/
guava or ½
green mango
(GI 31–41)

Boiled unripe
saba (GI 52) —
no sugar
added

HOW TO READ PAGES 2–3:



AVOID

= High GI >70 or High GL ≥20



LIMIT

= Medium GI 56–70 or Medium GL 11–19



GOOD

= Low GI <55 and Low GL ≤10

73

GI value

33

GL value

GI

=Glycemic Index

GL

=Glycemic Load per Serving

Food Item (Filipino Name)	Typical Serving	GI	GL	Rating	Key Note
A · BIGAS AT BUTIL — RICE & STAPLE GRAINS					
White rice, steamed (kanin)	1 cup cooked	73	33	AVOID	Biggest blood sugar spike in the Filipino diet; replace with ½ cup brown/basmati rice + kamote
Glutinous rice / malagkit (sinukmani, biko)	½ cup cooked	98	34	AVOID	Highest GI staple in Filipino cuisine; near-pure amylopectin starch — rapid glucose release
Lugaw / congee / arroz caldo (rice porridge)	1 bowl 300 mL	78	20	AVOID	Over-cooking breaks starch into simple glucose; spikes faster than steamed rice; try oatmeal instead
Brown rice (pilit na kayumanggi)	1 cup cooked	68	31	LIMIT	Only slightly lower GI than white; main benefit is fiber and micronutrients; still needs portion control
Basmati rice (aged, cooked)	1 cup cooked	58	26	LIMIT	Best rice variety for diabetes; long-chain amylose starch digests more slowly — keep to ½ cup per meal
Rolled oats, soaked overnight (Quaker)	½ cup dry	42	11	GOOD	Best breakfast carb for diabetes; beta-glucan soluble fiber blunts glucose rise; do NOT add condensed milk
Monggo / green mung bean (boiled)	1 cup cooked	31	11	GOOD	Excellent low-GI protein + fiber staple; sauté with malunggay in canola oil for a diabetes-friendly meal
Red kidney beans / munggo pula (boiled)	1 cup cooked	24	8	GOOD	Very low GI; high in resistant starch and protein; use in sinigang or as rice replacement in soups
B · TINAPAY AT MIE — BREAD, PASTA & NOODLES					
White bread (Gardenia, Marby, Bimbo)	2 slices	71	20	AVOID	Digested almost as fast as white rice; refined flour → rapid glucose spike; choose whole grain instead
Instant noodles (Lucky Me Pancit Canton)	1 pack	72	28	AVOID	Palm-oil fried noodles + very high sodium + MSG; double hit of high GI + high GL; worst noodle choice
Puto (steamed white rice cake)	3 pieces	75	22	AVOID	Refined rice starch, rapidly digested; popular merienda but spikes blood sugar quickly
Whole wheat bread (Gardenia Wheat, fibrous)	2 slices	69	16	LIMIT	Marginally better than white bread; check label — "wheat flour" ≠ whole grain; look for "whole wheat" as first ingredient
Pasta / spaghetti (al dente, plain)	1 cup cooked	57	22	LIMIT	Al dente = lower GI; overcooking raises GI significantly; avoid sweet Filipino-style spaghetti sauce
Sotanghon / glass noodles (mung bean starch)	½ cup cooked	35	10	GOOD	Best noodle for diabetes; mung bean starch is naturally low GI; use in soup with vegetables and chicken
Bihon rice noodles (steamed, not fried)	½ cup cooked	40	12	GOOD	Lower GI than wheat pasta; avoid stir-fried pancit versions with sweet soy sauce — adds sugar fast
C · ROOT CROPS AT STARCHY VEG — ROOT CROPS & STARCHY VEGETABLES					
Kalabasa / pumpkin (boiled, mashed)	1 cup	75	13	AVOID	Very high GI despite low GL; eat only small portions combined with protein to blunt spike
Cassava / kamoteng kahoy (boiled)	½ cup	65	15	LIMIT	Medium GI; avoid processed cassava products (cassava cake, nilupak with sugar) — GI becomes very high
Corn on the cob / mais (boiled, no butter)	1 medium cob	59	12	LIMIT	Whole corn better than cornstarch; fiber intact; avoid corn syrup products; good occasional merienda
Kamote / sweet potato (boiled, not baked)	1 medium 150g	44	12	GOOD	Best root crop for diabetes; boiling is key — baking raises GI to 94; rich in fiber, potassium, and beta-carotene
Gabi / taro (boiled, plain)	½ cup	54	8	GOOD	Good low-GI root crop; use in sinigang instead of potato; avoid gabi desserts with sugar or coconut cream
D · PRUTAS — FRUITS					
Watermelon (pakwan)	2 cups cubed	80	8	AVOID	Very high GI despite low GL; fast glucose release; choose guava or green mango instead
Very ripe mango / hinog na mangga	1 medium	73	17	AVOID	The riper, the higher the GI; at peak ripeness, fructose and glucose content spikes blood sugar fast
Lanzones, lychee, rambutan (fresh)	10 pieces	72	15	AVOID	High simple sugar content; easy to over-eat; limit to 5 pieces maximum if eaten with protein
Ripe mango (slightly firm), half portion	½ small mango	60	14	LIMIT	High fructose even at medium GI; limit to ½ small mango; eat with protein to slow glucose absorption
Papaya (ripe, hinog na papaya)	1 cup cubed	59	8	LIMIT	Moderate GI but low GL; reasonable in portions; enzyme papain may modestly improve glucose metabolism
Pineapple / pinya (fresh)	½ cup	66	9	LIMIT	Higher GI than expected; bromelain enzyme may have modest benefits; limit to small portions
Bayabas / guava (green-yellow, local)	1 medium	31	4	GOOD	Highest fiber of all Philippine fruits; excellent for blood sugar control; eat 1–2 daily as merienda
Green mango / hilaw na mangga	1 small	41	5	GOOD	Same fruit as ripe mango — but low GI unripe; eat with bagoong-free dip; very popular and diabetes-friendly
Avocado / abokado	½ medium	15	1	GOOD	Near-zero carb; rich in heart-healthy monounsaturated fat; excellent pairing with rice meals to lower overall GI
Dalandan / ponkan / suha (citrus)	1 medium	38	5	GOOD	Slow-releasing fructose + vitamin C; eat whole fruit — juice removes fiber and concentrates sugars

Food Item (Filipino Name)	Typical Serving	GI	GL	Rating	Key Note
E · GULAY — NON-STARCHY VEGETABLES · EAT FREELY · LOW GI ALWAYS					
Ampalaya / bitter melon (ginisa or raw)	1 cup	17	1	GOOD	Traditional diabetes superfood; charantin and polypeptide-p have documented blood-glucose-lowering effects
Okra (steamed or in sinigang)	1 cup	20	2	GOOD	Viscous mucilage fiber slows glucose absorption in the gut; eat daily — best vegetable for diabetes
Malunggay / moringa (leaves, steamed)	½ cup	20	1	GOOD	Rich in quercetin and chlorogenic acid; modestly lowers blood sugar; add to tinola, sinigang, or monggo
Kangkong / water spinach (ginisa)	1 cup	15	1	GOOD	Abundant and affordable; sauté in canola oil + garlic; excellent iron and vitamin source
Sitaw / string beans · talong · labanos	1 cup	28	3	GOOD	All low-GI vegetables; fill half the plate with these before eating rice; no quantity restriction
Pinakbet (mixed vegetables, canola oil, no bagoong)	1 cup	22	3	GOOD	Ideal Filipino diabetes dish; okra + ampalaya + talong in canola oil; skip bagoong (sodium) and lard
Kalabasa / pumpkin (added to sinigang)	½ cup	75	7	LIMIT	High GI but very low GL in normal portion; always eat with protein in a full meal to blunt impact
F · PROTINA AT LEGUMES — PROTEINS & LEGUMES					
Galunggong / round scad (grilled or steamed)	2–3 pieces	0	0	GOOD	Best budget omega-3 fish in PH; no glycemic impact; grill or steam — avoid frying in coconut oil
Tilapia / bangus / labahita (grilled/steamed)	1 medium	0	0	GOOD	Zero GI; lean protein that slows glucose absorption when eaten before carbs; eat daily
Sardinas sa kamatis (canned, tomato sauce)	1 can	5	0	GOOD	Affordable omega-3; zero glycemic load; choose tomato sauce — NOT oil or cream; watch sodium in CKD
Chicken breast, grilled (no skin)	1 piece	0	0	GOOD	Zero GI; the quarter-plate protein; tinola with malunggay is one of the best diabetic Filipino meals
Tokwa / firm tofu (fresh or steamed)	½ block	15	1	GOOD	Plant protein; replaces pork in adobo and scrambles; soy protein modestly improves insulin sensitivity
Boiled egg (itlog)	1 large	0	0	GOOD	Zero carbs; excellent merienda protein; limit to 1/day if LDL is also elevated; avoid tocino/egg combos
Longganisa / tocino (sweet-cured pork)	2 links / 2 slices	45	5	LIMIT	Added sugar in cure raises GI for a "protein" food; high sat fat + sodium compound cardiovascular risk
Lechon / chicharon / pork skin (crispy)	100g	0	0	AVOID	GI is zero but saturated fat impairs insulin sensitivity over time; worsens CKD and cardiovascular risk
G · INUMIN — BEVERAGES					
Softdrinks (Coke, Sprite, Royal, Pepsi)	1 can 330 mL	65	26	AVOID	35–40g sugar per can; liquid glucose has almost no delay — one can = equivalent of nearly 3 tsp of sugar direct
3-in-1 coffee (Nescafe, Great Taste, Kopiko)	1 sachet	70	18	AVOID	Non-dairy creamer (palm oil fat) + sugar = simultaneous fat + carb glucose spike; switch to black brewed barako
Powdered juice (Tang, 8 O’Clock, Zesto)	1 glass 250 mL	68	22	AVOID	Pure sugar + artificial color + no nutrients; one of the largest contributors to diabetes in Filipino diet
Commercial fruit juice (Minute Maid, Tropicana)	1 glass 250 mL	68	19	AVOID	Fiber removed; fructose concentrated; spikes blood sugar almost identically to sweetened drinks despite "fruit" label
Milo / Ovaltine (prepared, 2 tsp powder)	1 cup	55	14	LIMIT	Moderate sugar; use only 1 tsp powder with skim milk; never add condensed milk; limit to once/day
Buko / coconut juice (fresh, no added sugar)	1 coconut	55	11	LIMIT	Natural sugars; potassium-rich; acceptable hydration option if renal function is normal; avoid bottled sweetened versions
Black coffee / barako (brewed, no sugar)	1–2 cups	0	0	GOOD	Zero GI; chlorogenic acid in coffee improves insulin sensitivity; 2 cups/day associated with lower T2DM risk
Salabat / ginger tea (fresh, no arnibal)	1 cup	5	0	GOOD	Gingerol improves insulin signaling; ideal post-meal drink; anti-inflammatory; traditional Filipino remedy
Unsweetened calamansi juice (fresh)	1 glass + water	30	2	GOOD	Vitamin C; low sugar when no arnibal added; also lowers GI of rice when added directly to cooked rice
H · KAKANIN AT MATAMIS — FILIPINO SWEETS & DESSERTS					
Biko / sinukmani (glutinous rice + gata + sugar)	1 piece	95	48	AVOID	Highest GI and GL of all Filipino sweets; malagkit + coconut cream + brown sugar = triple spike trigger
Leche flan	1 slice 100g	62	30	AVOID	Egg yolk + condensed milk + sugar = very high GL per slice; spikes blood sugar quickly despite medium GI
Halo-halo (full serving)	1 large glass	80	36	AVOID	Condensed milk + ube ice cream + arnibal + kaong + sweetened beans = multiple sugar layers; worst dessert for DM
Maja blanca / bibingka / champorado	1 serving	72	24	AVOID	All are high-GI, high-GL Filipino desserts; refined carb + sugar + coconut cream combination to avoid
White sugar / arnibal / condensed milk	1 tsp / 2 tbsp	65–100	14+	AVOID	Pure glucose/fructose; remove from drinks, rice, and condiments; stevia or monk fruit are zero-GI alternatives
Boiled saba banana (slightly unripe)	2 pieces	52	14	LIMIT	Resistant starch when slightly unripe; do NOT fry, caramelize, or add sugar; eat as merienda with 1 boiled egg
Puto (plain, no butter, small)	2 pieces	68	15	LIMIT	Lower fat than most kakanin but still high refined carb; if eaten, pair with protein and keep to 2 small pieces

🇵🇭 7-Day Filipino Diabetic Meal Plan — Follow the Plate Rule Every Day (½ Veg · ¼ Protein · ¼ Carbs · Eat in Order)

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Merienda	Dinner
Mon	Quaker oatmeal + boiled egg + black barako coffee	Sinigang na tilapia + ½ cup cold rice + pinakbet (okra + talong)	1 guava + 1 boiled egg	Monggo guisado with malunggay + boiled kamote (no rice)
Tue	Ginisang ampalaya at itlog + ½ cup brown rice + salabat	Tinolang manok (breast, no skin, with malunggay) + ½ cup rice	Green mango + 30g pili nuts	Inihaw na bangus (no skin) + ginisang kangkong + ½ cup basmati rice
Wed	Overnight oats (with calamansi, no sugar) + dalandan	Sardinas sa kamatis + sitaw at kalabasa guisado + ½ cup cold rice	2 boiled saba (unripe) + salabat	Chicken adobo sa puti (breast, no skin) + steamed labanos + ½ cup rice
Thu	Scrambled tokwa + tomato + black coffee (no sugar)	Grilled galunggong + pinakbet (canola oil, no bagoong) + ½ cup rice	1–2 guavas fresh	Monggo at dilis + kangkong + boiled kamote instead of rice
Fri	Oatmeal + 1 boiled egg + calamansi juice (unsweetened)	Sinigang na bangus sa sampalok + okra + talong + ½ cup rice	½ avocado + water	Steamed tilapia + malunggay soup + sotanghon guisado (no sugar)
Sat	Scrambled egg + tomato + brown rice (½ cup) + black coffee	Paksiw na bangus (light vinegar, no pork) + sitaw + ½ cup cold rice	Ponkan + 1 boiled egg	Lumpiang sariwa (fresh, no fried) + tokwa filling + ½ cup rice
Sun	Overnight oats + sliced green mango (no sugar) + salabat	Nilagang manok (breast only) + malunggay + boiled kamote (no rice)	1 guava + water	Sardinas + ampalaya con huevo (1 egg) + ½ cup basmati rice

Diabetes Medications & Food Interactions

Metformin	Take WITH meals to avoid nausea. Long-term use depletes Vitamin B12 — check B12 yearly. No food causes dangerous interaction.
Sulfonylureas (glibenclamide, glipizide)	MUST eat within 30 min of taking tablet. Skipping or delaying meals → hypoglycemia risk. Keep sugar (3 pcs candy) on hand.
SGLT2 Inhibitors (empagliflozin, dapagliflozin)	Drink 6–8 glasses water/day (loses glucose via urine → dehydration risk). Reduce rice and sugar intake for best effect. Avoid if UTI active.
GLP-1 Agonists (semaglutide, dulaglutide)	Nausea worsens with high-fat meals (lechon, gata dishes). Eat small, low-fat meals. Avoid large rice portions — delays gastric emptying further.
Insulin	Keep carb intake consistent at each meal (same amount of rice each day). Skipping meals or eating late → hypoglycemia or hyperglycemia. Never skip meal after injecting rapid insulin.

Lifestyle Changes That Lower HbA1c

Walk After Meals ↓ Post-meal glucose 10–15% Even 10 minutes of brisk walking after eating significantly lowers the 2-hour glucose spike. Do it every day after lunch and dinner.	🏆 Lose 5–7% Body Weight ↓ HbA1c 0.5–1% In prediabetes, 5–7% weight loss prevents progression to diabetes in 58% of cases. Focus on rice portions first.
Cut Rice in Half Fastest HbA1c drop Reducing white rice from 3 cups to 1 cup/day is often the single most impactful diet change for Filipino diabetic patients.	Sleep 7–8 Hours Improves insulin sensitivity Sleep deprivation raises cortisol and glucose independently. Poor sleep can raise fasting glucose by 10–15 mg/dL.
⚠️ Special Situations Fasting (religious): Consult doctor before fasting. Sulfonylurea/insulin doses must be adjusted. Eat suhur with low-GI foods (oatmeal, monggo). Break fast with dates + water, then protein before carbs. Sick day: Never skip diabetes medications when ill. Monitor glucose every 4–6 hours. Drink clear fluids. Contact doctor if glucose >300 mg/dL or you cannot eat.	

For educational use only. This guide does not replace your physician's or dietitian's advice. Glycemic targets and medication adjustments are individualized. References: ADA Standards of Care 2025 · Atkinson et al. Am J Clin Nutr 2021 (GI Tables) · KDIGO 2024 · FNRI Philippine Food Composition Tables 2023.